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Open Source Committee Interview Report Summary

Maintainer Retainer Program (MRP)

Following a careful review of the 10 applicants in the third round of the Maintainer Retainer Program (MRP), the Open Source Committee (OSC) selected 7 individuals for onboarding. The 3 Maintainers that were not selected, were unable to adequately answer interview questions, additionally it was difficult to prove ties to and experience within the Cardano ecosystem. This selection process included separate interviews with project teams (when required) to ensure strong alignment and cohesion. The final round of interviews featured a cohort of candidates that presented unique technical expertise inside and outside of the Cardano ecosystem. The selections reflect a focused approach to support desirable community projects and fulfillment of a mission to expand the reach of the Maintainer Retainer Program.

Benard Ochanda - **(https://github.com/ochicode)** *No project defined*
Benard "Ben" Ochanda is a Nairobi-based full-stack developer and former tech lead with three and a half years of experience, whose Cardano exposure comes through employment at Lido Nation, a well-known Cradano community project, rather than public open-source contribution.

- Technical Profile: Strongest in PHP/Laravel with Vue and React, built at Lido Nation and carried through a tech lead role at Direct Development and his current position at Oxbridge AIX. He has worked with smart contracts and nodes on Polygon and Ethereum, but not on Cardano, and has no Haskell experience; he self-assesses his Cardano knowledge as junior. This places him on the off-chain and application side, with the Cardano-specific layer still ahead of him.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: His Cardano-relevant work (a proposal-submission platform and a second product at Lido Nation) sits in private repositories under NDA, leaving no publicly verifiable contribution record. His enablement strength is organizational rather than repository-facing: as tech lead he onboarded junior developers across multiple concurrent teams and worked directly with stakeholders. He offers 30 hours per week, above the program's commitment threshold.

- Code Review & Quality: Experienced in reviewing PRs, running parallel projects, and unblocking contributors, but exercised inside closed commercial teams rather than open ecosystem repositories.

Daniel Mwihoti (https://github.com/mwihoti) - *LSM Tree*
Daniel is the earliest-career candidate in this cohort: a developer active at Blockchain Center and in Kenya's Cardano community, with roughly six months of open source contribution behind him, plus prior work on a Bitcoin project.

- Contribution Record: His contributions so far centre on documentation, working through the codebase module by module and checking with the maintainer on which to take up next, a sustained working relationship rather than isolated drive-by PRs.

- Attitude & Growth: Frames open source primarily as a forcing function for learning, and credits it with visible gains in his communication and technical ability over six months. Works by confirming the objective before starting, asking questions where the brief is unclear, and accepting review feedback readily. Persistence is his strongest trait: he cites early rejection as his hardest experience and kept submitting regardless.

Ian Njuguna (https://github.com/IanoNjuguna) - *Developer Experience*
Ian is an ambitious, community-active developer from Kenya who came to Cardano in 2025 from a systems programming background, and is upfront about his ambition to become a core protocol engineer. That places his application ahead of his current experience, but it rests on substantial independent building.

- Technical Profile: Leads a music tokenization platform end to end, using smart contracts to issue records as NFTs and split royalties and masters across artists, collaborators, and their teams; comfortable with Aiken and the NFT standards (CIP-68 and the original).

- Approach to a New Codebase: Deliberate and culture-aware. Enter through the documentation, follow it exactly as written, then work inward with minor changes while checking coding standards with the engineers, on the principle that every project has a culture a newcomer should be useful within rather than disrupt. His stated skill is making heavy tooling run on mid-range machines and documenting that for others in the same position, which has direct value for widening the contributor base.

- Collaboration: Navigated a repository requiring four separate reviewer sign-offs on every PR by building rapport through the project's twice-weekly meetings rather than pressing for merges, and treats review friction as normal and constructive. His earliest open source memory: watching twenty people edit a commit message he had written, left him with a broad view of what contribution means, including triage and review, not just code.

Kushal Acharya (https://github.com/kusssal) - GovTool
Kushal has been in Cardano for about a year and a core contributor to GovTool for roughly four months, working across three repositories: the core GovTool repo and both the proposal and outcomes pillar repos. He offers 20–30 hours per week.

- Technical Profile: Works across code and infrastructure, including DevOps on GovTool and its related tooling, cardano-node and Docker. He came to Cardano from Ethereum, where he built a DeFi charity donation system in Hardhat and found the learning curve steep; he considers Cardano's stack easier to build on and values the UTxO model's similarity to Bitcoin. He identifies GovTool's Haskell backend as the main barrier to outside contribution and proposes keeping the core in Haskell while simplifying the backend. He has already rewritten the whole backend as a side project.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: His stated favourite part of open source is finding and filing issues: he opened an issue in the Hydra repository while working with Hydra, and worked a GovTool issue on direct delegation for script-based DReps. On supporting other contributors his answer was thin: collaborating on issues and replying to PR comments, no concrete example offered. To grow contribution he suggests promoting the project on social platforms such as Twitter and Reddit, alongside lowering the Haskell barrier.

- Code Review & Quality: He described the standard outside-contributor path: fork the repository, open a PR, request review from the maintainers, who in his experience responded readily without needing to be chased. He named no code review he has performed, and when asked for the hardest problem he has faced answered generally: getting familiar with an unfamiliar tech stack. There is little evidence either way on his review or quality practice.

Adriano Fiorenza (https://github.com/zxpectre) - *Dandelion Lite*
Adriano is a strong, self-sufficient maintainer: a full-stack developer of some fifteen years and founder of GameChanger Wallet, in Cardano full-time since the Plutus Pioneers programme. He applies to maintain Dandelion Light, the community infrastructure project he helps sustain, alongside the GameChanger repositories he has progressively released under MIT.

- Technical Depth: GameChanger is a transaction builder as well as a signing wallet, driven by a JSON- and link-based DSL designed to onboard new developers, supported by a library, CLI tool, over a hundred open source examples, and a full language reference. He also maintains a witness-pairing service that lets browser wallets and backend services co-sign multisig transactions, now powering another multisig wallet.

- Problem Solving: When the general-purpose GraphQL API degraded under Cardano's growth and cost him users, migrating elsewhere proved impossible, so he rewrote the API from scratch in a modern form to keep the wallet performant, and intends to open source it. He describes this as the most painful episode of his five years, and characteristically chose the hard path over quitting the dependency.

- Governance & Motivation: Runs weekly governance calls for Dandelion Light and deliberately resolves disagreement there rather than in GitHub threads, regularly shipping features requested by node operators that he had no need for himself. He is explicit that his aim in seeking support is to reduce the concentration of maintenance over his own head and widen participation, the same decentralization logic behind Dandelion Light, which lets less experienced operators deploy a node plus APIs.

Akshay "Ash" Dhayal (https://github.com/starkdevx) - *No project defined*

Ash is a software developer at Ola Electric in India with a Solana and Rust background, and no prior Cardano experience.

- Technical Profile: Five to six years in TypeScript and Next.js across full-stack and backend work, plus Rust from writing Solana programs, TCP servers and REST endpoints. He has never built on Cardano and has no Haskell, though he offered to learn. He states 20–30 free hours per week. Of the repositories he applied to, TxPipe's Oura is Rust and the only plausible fit, subject to a project interview and TxPipe's own judgment on proficiency.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: His enablement work is written rather than review-based: blogs, documentation and beginner tutorials, including a guide to writing Solana smart contracts in Python aimed at lowering the barrier for newcomers. He also emphasizes direct interaction with beginners to clear blockers early. Asked about supporting other contributors, he stated plainly that he enjoys contributing far more than reviewing and has done little review work.

- Code Review & Quality: Little evidence on either. He confirmed "not much" code review work and prefers contributing over reviewing, and he described no testing, CI, or merge-quality practice at any point in the interview. He was able to demonstrate product judgment: a Bloomberg-terminal-style CLI for Solana that he took to 60–70% completion, then rebuilt as a Solana program testing utility after users told him developers had no need for price data in a terminal, evidence that he acts on critical feedback rather than defending a design.

Adam Dean (https://github.com/Crypto2099) - *Ekklesia Tech Stack*
Adam Dean has built open-source Cardano tooling since 2019 and is a founding OSC member, former TSC member and long-serving CIP editor; he is the chief architect of Ekklesia, the Hydra-powered on-chain voting stack now used for Intersect's own elections.

- Technical Profile: Ekklesia is almost entirely JavaScript and TypeScript, with Docker and Makefile-driven commands for standing up the stack and MongoDB as the backing store (no Haskell, though it tracks Hydra and cardano-node releases). It is split across seven repositories rather than a monorepo, with the API decoupled from the UI: Civitas, CGov and several explorers queried it directly during the budget process and CC election. In governance tooling since 2020, he aligned v1 and v2 to draft CIP-179 and targets full parity in v3.0.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: Adam contributes upstream to the tools he depends on (bugs resolved with the Hydra team, PRs into TxPipe's TX3 libraries). Noting that outside code contribution is rare on Cardano while user feedback is abundant, he coaches users into filing public issues rather than accepting quiet side-channel fixes, building a searchable record of edge cases. Incoming PRs go through a contributing guide and CI gates, which he frames as a security control as much as a quality one.

- Code Review & Quality: Names "learning to tell people no" as the hardest part of maintenance, holding a release cadence rather than absorbing every request. His approach to conflict is preventative: define code ownership and decision rights up front so disputes have a settled path, and distinguish respectful disagreement from griefing. Years as a CIP editor show in his habit of line-level review markup left open for the contributor to resolve.

- Program Scope & Proposal: Catalyst-funded (Fund 13; Fund 14 final milestone awaiting sign-off), with Mad Orchestra as co-maintainer. Rather than transferring Ekklesia to Intersect (which he argues would bias Intersect toward one voting tool), he proposes incubating it as a self-governing sub-organization on the Linux Foundation model, reporting to the OSC, with Intersect providing administrative and legal support and holding fork rights as a backstop. Maintenance work would concentrate on the backend (which needs a secure admin interface) and the docs repo, the single issue-intake point across all seven repositories.

Akilimali Cizungu (https://github.com/Innocent-Akim) - *Dandelion Lite*
Akim is a software engineering graduate based in Goma (Democratic Republic of the Congo), who entered Cardano through Catalyst and has since supported several ecosystem teams, helping the local Goma-based team get their platform live and contributing to the translation of the Gimbalabs Plutus Project-Based Learning platform.

- Technical Profile: Works across C#, JavaScript, TypeScript, and Python, with around three years in TypeScript and React-based stacks, built a college and university management system. He currently volunteers on *Fikiri*, open source platform he volunteers on for UNFPA (the United Nations Population Fund), whose purpose is to capture and catalogue local community activities: it maintains a list of projects, and someone looking to get involved can browse and apply filters to find one that interests them. Essentially a discovery directory matching people to community initiatives.

- Contribution Record: His merged work in the ecosystem is modest but genuine: a fix to the Intersect website and a layout fix in Mesh, both accepted, after which local work commitments kept him from building momentum, a constraint he says has since eased. Separately, his very first open source pull request was opened cold, with no prior discussion; the maintainers' feedback taught him that agreeing the intent with the repository owner first produces a better contribution, and he has worked that way since.

Attitude & Gaps: Frames open source primarily as an opportunity to learn from how others write code. His best experience was joining a C# legacy codebase as the team's only C# developer and landing a contribution within a week of a three-week ramp.

Sudip Bhattarai (https://github.com/mesudip) - *GovTool*

Sudip has been active in Cardano for over four years and involved with *GovTool* since the project's start, first on the QA team building integration and backend tests, more recently running a pilot that took over the project's infrastructure maintenance and hosting. He is applying to continue as GovTool maintainer.

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- Technical Profile: His hands-on strength is operational: hosting and maintaining cardano-node and DB Sync, which is what the GovTool infrastructure pilot exercised. He has also shipped features into GovTool, including vote comments, and has integrated cardano-api into a Haskell application, the basis for his claim to know cardano-api and the ledger API in depth, with the caveat that both change fast enough that a year away means relearning. On Haskell specifically, he argues GovTool's backend does not demand much of it: the logic is mostly SQL, with Haskell routing requests to queries against DB Sync's database, and no need to touch DB Sync's own code. He would be confident with deeper Haskell work if the project required it. Elsewhere he has worked with Aiken, Blockfrost and Koios.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: Strong instincts here. He supports core contributors by reviewing their PRs and newcomers by walking them through the code structure and what their PR is missing. His clearest example: a contributor submitted a promising PR they could not get working, so he stood up a temporary environment against a live API so both he and they could see the change run. His reasoning is that anyone who opens a PR has already shown willingness, so removing an environment or integration obstacle is worth the extra step. He also treats issue reporting as first-class contribution, filing detailed issues upstream and submitting PRs himself where the fix is trivial.

- Code Review & Quality: Reviews GovTool PRs without being contractually required to, which he cites as what he values most about open source. On conflict, he reports no significant disputes but describes a considered method: understand why the other person wants their approach, explain his own, and decide by laying out the trade-offs (typically implementation time) of each path. He has no experience contributing to a repository where he lacked access or a line to the maintainer, so his ability to land work as an outside contributor is untested.

Hoang Vu Dinh (https://github.com/hadelive) - *Cardano node, Ouroboros network and Cardano Ledger*
Hoang is a senior engineer with roughly seven years in software and five in Cardano, whose work spans production Haskell, transaction-builder libraries, and the off-chain tooling stack that much of the ecosystem depends on.

- Technical Profile: Joined Cardano in 2021 learning Haskell at MLabs, where he built a transaction builder and a Polygon–Cardano bridge on the cardano-node libraries. At Anastasia Labs he contributed to Aiken Design Patterns, a linked-list library, and other audited on-chain work, and co-built Lucid Evolution, the maintained fork of Alessandro Konrad's Lucid. At No Witness Labs he developed Evolution SDK, now hosted by Intersect. His Haskell is production-grade but dates from 2021–2022; he reads and modifies it comfortably, though he now works mainly in TypeScript.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: Long track record of upstream contribution across the ecosystem, including early work on the *Helios* smart contract language, where he worked directly with the author to debug a 10,000-line monorepo compiler, wrote contracts to surface bugs, and submitted both fixes and features. He works in the open by default: features are discussed in project Discord channels before a PR is raised, and he tags maintainers directly to move review along. He applied to *Cardano node, Ouroboros network* and *Cardano Ledger*, chosen because he had already read into those codebases while building his own transaction tooling.

- Code Review & Quality: Comfortable operating as an external contributor without authority. His pattern is to open a PR, engage the maintainer through review, and escalate in Discord where the issue is time-sensitive. He pointed to CML PR #351, a redeemer CDDL correction that was merged the same day it was raised, as an example of well-scoped work carrying its own case. Asked about conflict resolution, he reported no significant experience of disagreement to draw on.

Conclusion:
These interviews did two jobs at once. They assessed candidates, and they diagnosed projects. *GovTool* is the clearest case: two experienced contributors gave opposite readings of the same structure, one defending the separation of the proposal and outcomes pillars because each carries its own backend, the other conceding that the resulting spread is what makes the project hard for newcomers to enter. Ekklesia posed the more ambitious version: a proposal not for maintenance alone but for incubation on the Linux Foundation model, as a self-governing sub-organisation under Intersect's oversight, so that Intersect can support a voting tool without appearing to endorse one.

Several of the projects we discussed have seen little development for a year, though not for lack of interest: the contributors we interviewed had kept watching their issues and reviewing the occasional pull request throughout. What none of them could give, without being paid, was sustained development time.

Appendix: OSC Members completed scoring primarily at the Interview stage for the third round. The absence of graphics should not be interpreted to mean less of a review, yet a more focused approach to evaluating each developer alongside their presented skillsets.